C2 Grammar

Ellipsis and substitution

Avoid repetition the way fluent speakers do, by leaving words out or replacing them with so, do, one and not.

Native speakers rarely repeat whole phrases. They leave out words that are clear from context (ellipsis) or replace them with short words (substitution). Using these well makes your English sound natural and concise.

Device	Replaces	Example
one / ones	a countable noun	*I need a pen. Have you got a spare one?*
do / do so	a verb phrase	*She said she'd apologise, and she did so the next day.*
so / not	a whole clause	*Will it rain? I hope not. Is he coming? I think so.*
Ellipsis after auxiliaries	the rest of the verb phrase	*I haven't read it, but Sara has.*
Ellipsis after *to*	the infinitive phrase	*I didn't want to go, but I had to.*
Ellipsis in coordination	a repeated subject or verb	*Some ordered fish, others chicken.*

Mind the auxiliary. The auxiliary must match the verb you leave out: *He can swim, and so can she*; *They've finished, but we haven't*.

Common mistakes. *I think yes* and *I hope no* are not English: say *I think so* and *I hope not*. Also, *one* cannot replace an uncountable noun: *I prefer hot water to cold*, not *to cold one*.

Practice

1. Shorten: I haven't seen the film, but my brother has seen the film.

2. Reply with substitution: "Is the shop open on Fridays?" (you believe it is)
3. Correct the mistake: "Will we be late?" "I hope no."
4. Replace the repeated noun: I don't like the blue shirt; I prefer the red shirt.
5. Shorten: She wanted to leave early, but she wasn't allowed to leave early.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. I haven't seen the film, but my brother has.
2. I think so.
3. I hope not.
4. I don't like the blue shirt; I prefer the red one.
5. She wanted to leave early, but she wasn't allowed to.